Half-Life 2

Half-Life 2 scales well with processor performance. Since MSI's 915P Neo 2 did well on the PCMark CPU score, it came as no surprise when the board offered the best performance for this game. This is further confirmed when you consider the Gigabyte GA-8I915G-MF right at the bottom of the graph—it fared rather poorly in its CPU tests. Second place was taken by MSI's other Platinum offering, while third place went to Gigabyte's GA-8I915G Duo.

DOOM 3

Except for the MSI 915G Neo 2 that scored 27 fps, all other boards were stuck at 26.9. The results do not imply that the MSI 915G Neo is significantly better than the rest. It does show that the game was GPU-bound, and hence the scaling did not occur as expected.

In Conclusion

MSI's 915G Neo 2 and 915P Neo 2 Platinum boards were the best of the lot. Both boards performed equally well on all counts, and have good sub-systems that don't bog down when stressed. Moreover, their feature lists are endless, and a very generous package makes them excellent buys.

When you bring price to the equation, the GA-8I915G Duo comes out on top. At Rs 6,000, the Duo is priced at Rs 6,000, which is Rs 4,000 less than the MSI Platinum boards. Despite its relatively poor performance, the GA-8I915G-MF scores higher than the other boards simply because of its price. At Rs 5,300, the GA-8I915G-MF is priced nearly 50 per cent less than MSI's Platinum boards.

This, however, cannot take away the accolades that the MSI platinum series boards deserve. If you want the best motherboard for the Intel platform and don't mind the extra price, go for one of the MSI boards.

THE AMD PLATFORM

VIA, SiS and nVidia are the only vendors that manufacture chipsets for the AMD platform. While PCI-Express has made it to mainstream boards on Intel platforms, it hasn't quite made inroads into the AMD platform yet. A majority of the chipsets supporting AMDs still use AGP and PCI.

The AMD Athlon line is segmented on the basis of its interface socket: AMD has different chipsets supporting the 754-pin Athlon 64 and the 939-pin Athlon XP. A point to remember is that a system based on the 939-pin Athlon processor is relatively expensive compared to a 754-pin system. Since we are here focusing on a mid-range system, we will concentrate only on the 754 chipsets, and not the ones supporting 939-pin processors.

The majority of motherboards available for the Socket 754 Athlon 64 processors are either based on VIA's K8T800 or nVidia's nForce3 250 GB chipset. Both these chipsets are almost at par with respect to the features they offer. Remember that the socket 754 processors have a single-channel memory controller; dual-channel is found only in 939-processors. These two chipsets are generally used in the higher spectrum of the mid-range boards.

Motherboards based on these usually cost upwards of Rs 6,000. The SiS 760GX chipset also supports 754-pin Athlons, and it provides integrated video, which the former two chipsets lack.

Looking To The Future

As mentioned earlier, PCI-Express has yet to make a prominent appearance on the AMD circuit. That day, though, is not far away. nVidia and ATi have already launched chipsets supporting PCI-Express, and ATi has already made it to the Indian market, ATi launched their Radeon Xpress 200 chipset featuring PCI-Express technology for the AMD platform. Currently, only MSI has products based on this chipset—the others are expected to follow soon. Note that this chipset only supports 939-pin Athlon processors, which are expensive.

Since they don't come under the purview of this article, we shall discuss them in a forthcoming article.

nVidia has launched their nForce4 chipset with SLI technology, but it will take a while for that technology to show up.

The Comparison

So which is the best motherboard to go with an AMD 754-pin processor? To decide this, we tested the five AMD, three Asus, one MSI and one Gigabyte boards that arrived in our lab. Of these five boards, three were based on